
UDL for Little Learners

Quick Win Strategy Cards

One card per chapter · One barrier · One move · Try it tomorrow.

How to use these cards

There is one card for every chapter in UDL for Little Learners. Each card names the barrier the chapter addresses, the single highest-leverage move you can make right now, and a line from the book to anchor it.

You don't need to read the book first. Find the card for the part of your day that's most on your mind. Try the move. Then go read the chapter.



Jeff Horwitz

Horwitz Consulting Group

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udlforlittlearners.com

PART ONE What Is UDL? UDL for Little Learners · Quick Win	PART ONE Designing the Environment UDL for Little Learners · Quick Win	PART ONE Community & Connections UDL for Little Learners · Quick Win
QUICK WIN Add images to your written directions	QUICK WIN Label five things with images this week	QUICK WIN Greet every student by name at the door
THE BARRIER Students can't access text-only instructions	THE BARRIER Students are dependent on the teacher to navigate the space	THE BARRIER Students don't feel known before instruction begins
THE MOVE Next to every set of written directions, add a picture. Students who can't yet read will thank you -- and so will others you didn't realize were struggling.	THE MOVE Pick five containers, shelves, or areas. Add a picture label. Watch how quickly students stop asking where things are.	THE MOVE Stand at the door every morning. Use their name. Notice who seems off. This daily deposit, compounded over a year, is the foundation for everything else.
<i>"Adding images didn't just help one student -- it revealed how many others I'd been missing all along."</i>	<i>"The classroom is the first teacher. If students have to ask where pencils are, the room isn't teaching yet."</i>	<i>"Relationships don't happen during lessons. They happen in the doorway, in the moments before school starts."</i>
PART TWO Transitions UDL for Little Learners · Quick Win	PART TWO Reflection UDL for Little Learners · Quick Win	PART TWO Small Group Instruction UDL for Little Learners · Quick Win
QUICK WIN Teach one transition like a lesson	QUICK WIN Add one reflection question to closing circle	QUICK WIN Set up the small group table before students arrive
THE BARRIER Students don't know what to do -- so behavior fills the gap	THE BARRIER Students have no structured opportunity to own their learning	THE BARRIER The teacher is managing the room instead of teaching the group
THE MOVE Pick your hardest transition. Model it. Practice it without academic content. Name what it looks and sounds like. Then do it again.	THE MOVE End the day with one simple question. Use a sentence stem. Give them a moment. The answers will surprise you.	THE MOVE Before students arrive, have everything on the table. Starting without scrambling means more instructional minutes and a calmer group.
<i>"I told my kindergartners to line up and chaos ensued. They weren't misbehaving -- I just hadn't taught them yet."</i>	<i>"Trading five minutes of doing for five minutes of reflecting sounds like a trade-off. Research says it's more learning, not less."</i>	<i>"Small group is where UDL's power is most visible -- but only if the rest of the room is humming without you."</i>

PART TWO Emotional Literacy UDL for Little Learners · Quick Win QUICK WIN Create a calm corner with 2-3 clear choices THE BARRIER Students have nowhere to regulate, so dysregulation disrupts everyone THE MOVE Designate a corner. Add 2-3 tools: a feelings chart, something to squeeze, something to look at. Teach students to use it before they need it. "The calm corner isn't a reward and it isn't a punishment. It's a tool. Teach it like one."	PART TWO Centers UDL for Little Learners · Quick Win QUICK WIN Add visual directions to one center THE BARRIER A center that looks the same for everyone is just a station THE MOVE Pick one center. Add a picture-based direction card. Watch which students suddenly become independent who weren't before. "A center that every student accesses the same way, at the same level, with the same materials is just a station."	PART THREE Arrival & Morning Routines UDL for Little Learners · Quick Win QUICK WIN Create a visual arrival routine students navigate alone THE BARRIER The first five minutes set the tone -- and too often they're chaotic THE MOVE Post the arrival steps with pictures. Teach it in the first week. Then step back. The routine does the work. "A UDL-informed arrival is predictable, warm, and immediately purposeful. Students shouldn't be waiting -- they should be doing."
PART THREE Morning Meeting UDL for Little Learners · Quick Win QUICK WIN Replace one hand-raise with a think-pair-share THE BARRIER The same students answer every question -- others disappear THE MOVE Pick one moment where you usually ask for hands. Try a think-pair-share or four corners. Notice who shows up differently. "Morning meeting builds community, practices skills, and establishes belonging -- when done well."	PART THREE Calendar UDL for Little Learners · Quick Win QUICK WIN Add a movement element to one calendar routine THE BARRIER Calendar time asks students to sit and listen for too long THE MOVE Count the days with karate chops. Count by 5s like frogs hopping. One movement swap per week. The math stays the same; the engagement goes up. "When we ask who is doing the thinking and who is left out, we see both the potential and the missed opportunities."	PART THREE Phonics & Reading UDL for Little Learners · Quick Win QUICK WIN Add a movement response to one phonics practice THE BARRIER Whole-group phonics doesn't reach students at both ends of the spectrum THE MOVE When students practice a sound, tap it on their arm, stomp it, or show it with fingers. Multimodal practice reaches more learners. "There were students who found it too fast and others who already had the skills of the day. Both were being missed."

PART THREE Writing UDL for Little Learners · Quick Win QUICK WIN Set up a writing tool buffet THE BARRIER Writing is complex -- and we often add barriers before students start THE MOVE Put out pencils, crayons, markers, different paper types. Make it a buffet. Watch who reaches for what -- and wonder about why. <i>"UDL-aligned writing instruction removes barriers without removing the goal."</i>	PART THREE Recess UDL for Little Learners · Quick Win QUICK WIN Walk the playground -- notice who is on the margins THE BARRIER Recess is rarely designed -- students on the margins pay the price THE MOVE Take ten minutes. Walk the playground. Who is playing? Who is watching? Who is alone? What you notice will tell you what to change. <i>"You have more influence over recess than you think. The space, equipment, and supervision are largely in your hands."</i>	PART THREE Math UDL for Little Learners · Quick Win QUICK WIN Add a second problem at a different level to one warm-up THE BARRIER Warm-ups designed for the average student miss half the class THE MOVE Offer two versions: same concept, different numbers. Let students choose. Or everyone starts with A and moves to B when done. <i>"If we want flexible problem solvers, we need to give students flexible pathways to practice."</i>
PART THREE Read Aloud / Whole Group UDL for Little Learners · Quick Win QUICK WIN Use one think-pair-share during your next read aloud THE BARRIER Students are positioned as listeners rather than thinkers THE MOVE Stop once. Ask a question. Give students 60 seconds to talk before you continue. Every student thinks. Every student talks. <i>"A UDL-aligned read aloud positions every student as a thinker -- not just a listener."</i>	PART THREE Closing Circle & Dismissal UDL for Little Learners · Quick Win QUICK WIN Start a 5-minute closing circle routine this week THE BARRIER The end of the day is chaotic -- students leave unprocessed THE MOVE Gather for five minutes. One question. One sentence stem. That's it. Build the habit. The depth comes later. <i>"Closing circle is a way to intentionally design the end of the day for connection, regulation, and reflection."</i>	PART THREE Where to Go From Here UDL for Little Learners · Quick Win QUICK WIN Pick one part of your day and commit for two weeks THE BARRIER Trying to change everything at once leads to changing nothing THE MOVE Choose the chapter that hit closest to home. Pick one strategy. Try it every day for two weeks. Let success show you where to go next. <i>"Start small. Pick a part of your day. Get those routines running well and build from there."</i>